

Off the Shelf

Get your adrenaline rush with these power-packed game reviews

GLOBAL OPERATIONS

Send in the Experts

The rage in online gaming for the last couple of years has undeniably been *Counter-Strike* (CS), a team-based title that allows groups of terrorists and counter-terrorists to go head to head. An obvious offshoot of the CS craze, *Global Operations*



TUNNEL VISION: The Binoculars are one of the many toys you get to play with

from Barking Dog takes the original formula, adds a bit of innovation, and comes up with something that's tasteful.

You play a member of an elite military force such as the SAS or the Australian Special Operation forces, pitted against criminal organisations in Chechnya, Sri Lanka and the South China seas. Missions are team-specific, such as 'Rescue the hostage'

and 'Disarm the bomb'. Now before you say "Counter-Strike clone", *Global Operations* plays more like *Team Fortress* and less like CS, with a focus on team play, which is a non-existent aspect of CS. While CS is based more on individual combat, *Global Operations* focuses more on working with your team mates to complete your missions.

You can play one of six different roles: Recon, Commando, Medic, Heavy Gunner, Demo and Sniper. You have an arsenal of real-life weapons such as machine guns, shotguns and snipers, as well as accessories such as silencers, laser sights, and night vision goggles.

Missions begin with your characters being transported to the battleground. During this time, you are allotted some money much like in *Counter-Strike*, for purchasing your character's weaponry and equipment. Money is earned by killing enemies and completing mission objectives. Plus you have whatever is left over from purchases in the previous round.

The graphics aren't breathtaking in any way, especially when compared to games like *Serious Sam* and *Return to Castle Wolfenstein*. The animations and character movement are well done, as are the

weapons effects. When a grenade is hurled at you, the screen will go all blurry and you'll experience a hearing defect, followed by a long buzzing noise. These contribute a lot to the gameplay value.

The game is heavy on the Multiplayer aspect, and even the single player mission is dependent on bots, which are poorly programmed. While playing the game, the teammates routinely ran directly into the line of fire without regard for stealth. The AI proved to be weak at many spots and didn't give a team-based experience.

The game successfully fuses a wide variety of great weapons with character classes in a slick fashion, which is its winning argument. However, *Global Operations* does not measure up to the playability of *Counter-Strike*. If you're comfortable playing *Counter-Strike*, there is no compelling reason to pick up *Global Operations*. Poor network performance and irksome graphics require some patching, which should be available by the time this review reaches you.

Genre: Team Based FPS

Developer: Barking Dog Studios

Distributor: Gayatri Impex Pvt Ltd

Phone: 022-3881443

Web site: www.barkingdog.com

Price: Rs 1,299

Rating: ★★☆☆☆

4X4 EVOLUTION 2

Race on

If hardcore fun and racing reality is what you are looking for, then you can expect some rough riding and a face full of muck while playing this game! It has some amazingly realistic graphics with gravel and dust flying up in the air, and large open maps with some neat scenery. The tracks are very well thought out and lend

themselves well to the game's inherent physics. Running it on a GeForce3 powered machine allows the game to really shine. The only thing lacking in the graphics department is the damage effect to the trucks. The trucks remain as shiny as ever despite going through dirt, blasting through rocks, and falling off cliffs!

The game offers four different weather options, which include Clear, Foggy, Dense fog and Rain, and two different 'time of the day' options (Mid-day and Dusk). All these are brilliantly rendered and greatly improve the replay value of the game. It boasts of over 32 tracks and over 120 top-of-the-line trucks from Dodge,